

STRAY DOG OF ANIME

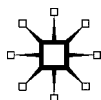


*The Films of
Mamoru Oshii*

SECOND EDITION

BRIAN RUH

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STRAY DOG OF ANIME
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CHAPTER NINE

GHOST IN THE SHELL 2: INNOCENCE (2004)

FOLLOWING THE SUCCESS OF THE ORIGINAL *Ghost in the Shell* in 1995, further animated explorations in the franchise began in October 2002 when the series *Ghost in the Shell: Stand Alone Complex* began airing on Japanese television. Directed by Kenji Kamiyama, who had made his directorial debut with *MiniPato* a year earlier, the series delved deeper into the world of Section 9, yet it took place in a different narrative universe. In many respects the television series was closer to Masamune Shirow's original manga than Oshii's film adaptation. Rather than the pan-Asian Hong Kong-influenced aesthetics of the film, the setting for *Stand Alone Complex* was undoubtedly Japan. In twenty-six episodes, the series took Shirow's original ideas for the *Ghost in the Shell* manga and incorporated them with other contributions from the staff, including staff writer Jun'ichi Fujisaku, who had previously worked on *Blood the Last Vampire* and who would go on to write a series of novels based in the *Stand Alone Complex* universe. In early 2004, a second series of the *Ghost in the Shell* television series began airing, again directed by Kamiyama. This

time around it was called *2nd Gig* and featured contributions from Oshii, who contributed to the overall structure and was credited with “story concept.” Although Oshii was now popularly associated with *Ghost in the Shell*, he had not wanted to interfere with what Kamiyama was doing until specifically asked to contribute by Production I.G’s cofounder Mitsuhsa Ishikawa.¹

Although Oshii has said that he “didn’t have much desire” to direct a follow-up to the original *Ghost in the Shell* film, he eventually relented, saying, “I suppose the biggest reason was that I was told by . . . Ishikawa that [I.G] would not do the job if I didn’t do it.”² The connection between Oshii, *Ghost in the Shell*, and Production I.G was a formative one. Ishikawa said, “*Ghost in the Shell* was a breakthrough in that it’s a borderless work. It opened up a market outside of Japan, gaining a lot of overseas attention and business opportunities. It also gave our studio an identity.”³ It, therefore, makes sense that this follow-up to *Ghost in the Shell* was given priority in the studio, both in terms of budget and time allotted to the project. However, even though the original film was an important work in showcasing Production I.G internationally, it was not particularly successful within Japan. (Ishikawa has estimated that only a tenth of *Ghost in the Shell*’s fan base is Japanese.⁴)

According to Oshii, once Studio Ghibli producer Toshio Suzuki was brought on board the project, the name was changed from *Ghost in the Shell 2* to simply *Innocence*. As Oshii explained, “since the first movie was never a success in Japan, there was absolutely no merit in establishing it as a sequel if we wanted to have this new movie take off here.”⁵ However, since *Ghost in the Shell* had already been hailed as a groundbreaking anime outside of Japan, in many territories the new film was called *Ghost in the Shell 2: Innocence*. (However, for our purposes, *Innocence* makes for a far shorter title, so I’ll be referring to the film by its Japanese name.)

CHARACTERS OF GHOST IN THE SHELL 2: INNOCENCE

Batou—A large cyborg still working for Section 9. Since Kusanagi’s merger with the Puppet Master at the end of the first *Ghost in the Shell* film,

he has been living a solitary existence, focusing on his job and his pet basset hound.

Togusa—A mostly human operative of Section 9 and Batou's partner. Although his skills cannot compare with those of Kusanagi, he is still one of the organization's sharpest agents. Since Togusa is married with a family, he often tries to temper Batou's more impulsive nature.

Major Motoko Kusanagi—Since she merged with the Puppet Master to create a new cybernetic being, she has not been seen or heard from. However, Batou still believes she is out there in the Net somewhere, watching them.

SYNOPSIS OF *GHOST IN THE SHELL 2: INNOCENCE*

The film begins with two brief paragraphs introducing Batou and Togusa, and mentions that Batou has been left in a state of limbo after Kusanagi "disappeared into the Net," as he keeps wondering about her and waiting for her return. It then displays a key epigraph from Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *Tomorrow's Eve*: "If our gods and our hopes are nothing but scientific phenomena, then it must be said that our love is scientific as well."

Batou drives his car through a throng of people milling about on a dense city street at night, countless neon signs illuminating the way. There is a large contingent of police officers already on the scene, wearing protective masks and body armor. From the people in charge, Batou learns that a series of murders has taken place—the criminal killed one person, fled, and later killed two police officers in an alley. As the officers prepare to advance on the alley, where they surmise the criminal is still hiding, Batou simply cocks his gun and begins walking down the alley himself. He takes in the scene, his cyberbrain identifying the remains of the dead cops, until he runs into what appears to be a young girl in a kimono. She sits on the stairs, cradling the decapitated head of one of the police officers. As Batou draws closer, she attacks him with a series of kicks, which the hulking cyborg blocks. With one punch from a shock glove he is wearing, Batou knocks her back into the

alley wall, where she remains motionless. As Batou draws his gun, he hears a female voice repeatedly saying “help me.” The girl begins convulsing, and grabs at the white skin on her chest, bloodlessly ripping it apart to reveal the mechanical workings underneath, cords and wires escaping from her chest cavity like viscera. The plates that form her face and head open as well, showing Batou a set of eyes and teeth set in an almost maniacal rictus. An explosion makes everything go white.

After the opening credit sequence, in which we see a cyborg being built much like the first *Ghost in the Shell* film. An egg is fertilized, then begins the process of cellular division. However, it soon grows and morphs into obviously inorganic structures, growing biological and electronic connections. Glowing tendrils pull together other body parts into a complete assembly—a hand, a torso, a ball-jointed whole figure. Fragments coalesce as the body rises through layers of indistinct liquid, arriving at the final close-up of the cyborg’s eye.

In his office, Chief Aramaki assigns Batou and Tougusa to investigate cases of prototype gynoids (female robots) that have killed their owners. Although such incidents would not normally be assigned to Section 9, two of the deceased were in politics, so they need to determine if this is a case of terrorism. In the forensics department of the police station, the two investigators meet Dr. Haraway, who is performing the analysis on the gynoid that Batou dealt with in the first scene. She asks him if the robot was trying to commit suicide when he shot her. This leads to a conversation between Tougusa and Haraway about whether a gynoid could in fact kill itself (due to the laws of robotics), the nature of self-awareness, and how this relates to human children. While there, they learn that the gynoid, made by the company Locus Solus, was actually a “sexaroid” designed for pleasure. It is evident from their conversation that such activities, while not prohibited by law, are not looked upon favorably by society at large.

Back in Batou’s car, they get a call that informs them of the murder of an inspector for Locus Solus named Jack Volkerson. Arriving at the scene, they find Ishikawa of Section 9 already there. They discover that Volkerson

had been killed with kitchen implements and his internal organs removed and stored in the refrigerator. There is evidence that an illegally modified cyborg had been at the scene and that a car linked to an organized crime group had been there as well. Looking through the rented boathouse where the deceased was discovered, Batou finds a copy of *The Doll* by Hans Bellmer on a bookshelf. Inside, he discovers a holographic picture of a young girl and pockets it. The Section 9 agents leave as the local police arrive to take command of the scene.

After relaxing at home and lovingly preparing some food for his pet basset hound, Batou returns to Section 9 headquarters, where he and the rest of the team are briefed on Volkerson's murder. All the evidence points to the involvement of the Koujinkai, an organized crime group whose leader had been killed by a Hadaly gynoid three days prior. Privately, Chief Aramaki later tells Togusa that Batou's recent behavior has been concerning him, reminding him of how Kusanagi had acted just before she disappeared. After securing a promise from Batou before just going in to talk, Togusa and Batou visit the headquarters of the Koujinkai. Batou tells them to get the new head of the gang, and when they begin to brandish their weapons, he quickly draws an assault rifle and begins raking the entire office with gunfire. Once reinforcements arrive, Batou is able to neutralize them by hacking into their visual processes, making them unable to see where he really is. They find the new boss of the Koujinkai up a flight of stairs, but first Batou has to defeat a large cyborg with a crab claw hand. The investigators learn that Locus Solus had told the boss where the gang could find Volkerson, but since he was recently out of prison the new Koujinkai head didn't know the connection between the gang and the corporation.

After Aramaki chews out Batou and Togusa for their assault on the yakuza offices, Togusa drops Batou off at his usual convenience store to pick up some dog food. As he enters, indistinct, whispering voices can be heard in the background while the overhead lights hum and pop. A metallic-edged woman's voice echoes in Batou's mind, saying, "You're in the kill zone." On edge, Batou scans his surroundings carefully, grabs three boxes

of dog food, and heads off to pay, his hand poised on his revolver. Suddenly, Batou's arm erupts in a plume of blood as bullets pierce his flesh. Chaos rages as Batou draws his guns, the glass on the refrigerated cases shatter, and items are knocked flying off the shelves. The other people in the store start running away from Batou as he scans around, his sensors compromised by static. The shopkeeper, armed with a shotgun, shoots at Batou, knocking him to the ground. As he reloads, Batou is quickly on his feet and surprises the shopkeeper with his speed, arriving at the counter and putting his pistol to the civilian's head. However, Ishikawa, unseen until now, is suddenly behind Batou with a device to his neck, temporarily immobilizing him.

Back at Section 9 headquarters, one of the technicians has given Batou a new cybernetic arm to replace the organic one he previously had. Ishikawa and Togusa, carrying Batou's basset hound, enter and tell him that someone had hacked into his brain and made him go berserk in the store, shooting himself and nearly killing the owner. Ishikawa chastises Batou for letting his guard down and for establishing predictable patterns of behavior that make him only more vulnerable. Batou's excuse is that that particular store is the only one that carries the specific kind of food his dog likes. However, since someone was willing to go to so much trouble to disgrace Batou, it seems to indicate that they are on the right track with their investigation, so he and Togusa head to the northern territories to pay a visit to Locus Solus themselves.

Locus Solus is located in a special economic zone that makes it difficult for police and regulators to reach. As a fantastic festival parade occurs around them, the two agents from Section 9 continue their investigation. Batou runs into an old informant acquaintance with a dubious past who helps lead them to Kim, an ex-military man now working in black market weapons and information. When Batou and Togusa enter Kim's mansion, they see a variety of amazing sights throughout the building. Stained glass and intricate colored tile line the walls and floor, while a giant music box with automatons of a dog and a girl crouched before it greet visitors in the

great hall. Before the girl are letter cards spelling out “aemaeth” (Hebrew for “truth”). Batou walks through a room with a ceiling painted to look like the sky—underneath it is a dinner party, frozen in time while a holographic fire rages across their table. An indoor courtyard is filled with a single tree and three-dimensional holograms of birds in flight. Togusa, however, finds Kim’s study on the top floor and Batou races to confront him.

Once there, however, Batou finds the cybernetic Kim apparently dead on a recliner, the victim of powerful antihacking software. Able to see through his ruse, Batou flips Kim’s body out of his chair and says that he doesn’t have time for Kim’s jokes, at which Kim begins laughing. Kim then proceeds to fill them in on *Locus Solus*, mentioning how the company has been growing recently and has begun manufacturing in international waters. They talk, as Kim waxes on about the similarities and differences between dolls, humans, and animals. Togusa finds a model of the mansion that pops out from an alcove in the wall, and as he looks at it carefully, the scene suddenly shifts to Togusa and Batou back outside Kim’s mansion. They enter again, and the decorations are not quite the same as before, and the cards before the girl in the entryway now spell out “maeth” (Hebrew for “death”). They head up to Kim’s study, where they find a mechanical replica of Togusa where Kim had previously been. Kim’s voice begins coming out of Togusa’s replica, talking about the uncanny nature of dolls and the illusion of life. Batou jerkily turns to face Togusa and the faceplate on his head opens to reveal the wires inside. As a gunshot rings out, the scene shifts to Batou and Togusa outside the mansion yet again. Hearing the echo of the gunshot, they race inside, where the scenery is again different. Notably, the girl and dog are now missing, replaced with cards that read “2501.” In Kim’s study, they now find a mechanical Batou replica. However, an unidentified naval vessel from the waters just offshore begins firing a barrage of weapons at them, destroying the mansion. Togusa is shot, falls down, and is shocked to see his own chest open in a tangle of wires. Back in the functioning and fully unharmed study, Batou has immobilized Togusa with a device to his neck, making him realize that Kim had hacked into his brain. Kim asks Batou when he had figured

out that Kim was tricking them. Batou responds that the girl with the dog he had seen in the hall (whom Kim had nothing to do with) was his guardian angel. Outside the mansion, Togusa questions again whether or not they are back in reality.

Togusa and Batou have evidence from Kim's e-brain that will convict him of cybercrimes, but Batou decides that to prove that Locus Solus is behind the gynoid murders, they need material evidence. Batou sneaks on-board the Locus Solus manufacturing ship while Togusa hacks into their security from another vessel not far away. Even though Locus Solus is able to detect Batou's intrusion, Togusa's countermeasures buy him some valuable time. The gynoids on the assembly line all activate, attacking both the onboard security personnel and Batou. One gynoid manages to get close to Batou, grabbing one of his holstered guns, and attacks the other gynoids. Batou realizes that this gynoid is in fact Kusanagi (or, as she puts it, just a fragment of her since there is not enough capacity in the gynoid's brain). Kusanagi and Batou fight their way through more gynoids to reach an emergency access panel, where Batou keeps the cyborgs at bay while Kusanagi hacks into Locus Solus's systems. Once successful, Kusanagi cuts off control to the gynoids and sets the ship on a course out of international waters to be apprehended.

Since they have time, Kusanagi and Batou investigate the Locus Solus production process. They find rows of "ghost dubbing" machines to take the "ghost" from living beings and impart them into the gynoids Locus Solus was selling. The Koujinkai had been kidnapping girls and selling them to Locus Solus, where their ghosts were transferred to the gynoids to give them that additional spark of desirability. Batou hears a girl's voice calling for help, and he opens one of the ghost dubbing machines and helps her out of it. It turns out that Volkerson had made changes to the gynoids to allow them to kill, and in so doing hoped that someone would notice and bring the misdeeds of Locus Solus to light. The major says farewell to Batou and leaves the doll, reminding him that she is always with him whenever he enters the Net.

COMMENTARY AND ANALYSIS

The genesis for the story in *Innocence* is a chapter in Masamune Shirow's original *Ghost in the Shell* manga called "Robot Rondo." Oshii's use of Shirow's source material highlights the fact that mixing and matching material from the comics and animation is a common practice for adaptations of *Ghost in the Shell*.⁶ However, the skeleton of the story was present in Shirow's original, albeit with significant differences. (As Oshii has jokingly put it, comparing his style with Shirow's, "our preferences in the details diverge—for instance, our tastes in guns are completely different."⁷) Although the original manga focuses on Batou and Togusa, chronologically it takes place before Kusanagi's encounter with the Puppet Master; yet she appears in the story. Some of the other differences include the fact that the analysis scene with Dr. Haraway takes place with Ishikawa, and more detail is shown regarding the corporate structure surrounding the organization manufacturing the malfunctioning robots (called Hanka Precision Instruments in the comic rather than Locus Solus). Another interesting difference is that the shipping inspector (named Kobunuma) has far less altruistic reasons for helping out the kidnapped children being used in the ghost-dubbing process to create the new prototype robots. He says that he had secretly made sure the robots would go berserk and wrote an "SOS" on their cyberbrains for police to find in exchange for two nights with two of the young victims.⁸ Unlike the Volkerson of *Innocence*, who seems to have been working only out of concern for the kidnapped children, Kobunuma is a morally compromised character, and as a consequence the reader feels less sympathy for him when he is assassinated by a gang sniper in revenge for one of the berserk robots having killed his boss.

The film's introductory paragraphs not only summarize (however cursorily) the events of the previous *Ghost in the Shell* film, but they prime the viewer for what is to come, setting expectations for the kind of film this is to be. It is fitting that it ends on a note of Batou's regretful longing, waiting

for Kusanagi to come back. This is something that is explored in even more detail in *Innocence: After the Long Goodbye* by Masaki Yamada, a tie-in novel that came out prior to the theatrical release of *Innocence* in Japan. Although Oshii is more well-known as a director, he originally wanted to be a science fiction writer, and was a particular fan of Ryū Mitsuse. In his new afterword to Mitsuse's *Ten Billion Days and One Hundred Billion Nights* (1967), Oshii recounts the time when, as a high school activist he had "infiltrated" his school library committee and "immediately began purchasing New Left texts" as well as science fiction. He was able to join the library newspaper as a reporter and used this as a pretense for arranging an interview with Mitsuse, which Oshii described as "a truly revolutionary abuse of public office for personal gain."⁹

In renaming both the robot model and the company that produces them—calling it the "Locus Solus 2052—'Hadaly' type"—Oshii adds depth to *Innocence* by incorporating allusions to existing literary works. In particular, Hadaly, the model of the gynoid that is going berserk, references the book *Tomorrow's Eve (L'Eve Future)* by Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, while the name of the manufacturer refers to *Locus Solus* by Raymond Roussel. Originally published in 1886 and 1914, respectively, these two French novels provide ways of examining *Innocence* that offer insights into the themes of the film.

Roussel's *Locus Solus* chronicles the experiences of an unnamed narrator whose friend Martial Canterel invites him and some other friends to visit his large estate, called Locus Solus. Canterel is a genius researcher and scientist who has created all manner of fantastic inventions, both practical and artistic. The book is a chronicle of everything the narrator sees at Locus Solus, as well as the background stories of how Canterel's fantastic installations came about, entailing stories within stories and multiple levels of narrative. However, aside from the individual tales, there is little in the way of overarching story. There is no tension and no climax. When the last sight has been described, the book ends, "Then Canterel, declaring that all the secrets of his park were now known to us, took the pack back to the villa where all of us were soon united at a cheerful dinner."¹⁰

As far as *Innocence* is concerned, of particular interest is Canterel's ability to scientifically revive the dead as a form of automaton. Upon the introduction of the substances *vitalium* and *resurrectine* and the application of an electric current, the person would begin acting out "every slightest action performed by him during certain outstanding minutes of his life; then, without any break, he would indefinitely repeat the same unvarying series of deeds and gestures which he had chosen once and for all. The illusion of life was absolute: mobility of expression, the continual working of the lungs, speech, various actions, walking—nothing was missing."¹¹ The reanimated dead at Locus Solus were not there as a ghoulish playground, but were there rather as a form of solace, as "Cantarel received many letters from frightened families who, out of affection, wished to see their loved ones live again before their eyes after the fatal moment."¹² So part of Locus Solus was given over to these reanimated humans and outfitted to accommodate the appropriate settings for their infinitely repeated actions. They were, in a sense, actors, and Roussel even describes their movements as a "role" they are playing.¹³

Although the book does not use the word "cyborg," this is essentially what Roussel has created in *Locus Solus*—entities that are part human, part technology. It only makes sense, then, that the company that creates that gynoids that are going berserk in *Innocence* is called Locus Solus. (It is certainly more evocative than Shirow's Hanka Precision Instruments.) In creating the gynoids, the company is taking the ghosts of kidnapped children and transferring them into the sex cyborgs, giving the mechanical creations a certain ineffable quality that they think will be marketable. In some ways, then, the Locus Solus of *Innocence* is the inverse of Roussel's villa—the company creates artificial life by taking it and causing pain and distress, rather than revising the previously dead and assuaging the guilt and fears of their friends and family. And yet, both *Innocence* and *Locus Solus* are in part about coping with loss and grief, and the possibilities of using technologies in order to be able to cope and move on. After Kusanagi's merger with the Puppet Master in the first film, Batou has become withdrawn, his primary relationship

being with his dog. He keeps watching for signs in the net, hoping and looking for signs of Kusanagi in his own way. As Mark Ford writes in his analysis of *Locus Solus*, “The novel as a whole evinces a profound melancholy, its narratives driven by an unappeasable yearning to salvage and reanimate by any means possible tokens or simulacra of the irretrievably lost.”¹⁴ Even though it is possible to repair and revive people in the world of *Innocence*, Kusanagi has become a being who is set apart from Batou. Regardless of what he does, there is a gap that he cannot close, no matter how hard he tries.

The other main literary influence on *Innocence*, *Tomorrow's Eve* was foundational work in its depiction of human/machine relations. The main protagonist is a fictionalized version of Thomas Edison, who is reunited with his old friend Lord Ewald, who is madly in love with a vapid and foolish young woman named Alicia Clary. The condition of her nature is a source of constant vexation for Ewald, who sees no way out for his emotions—he cannot live without her, but at the same time cannot stand to be around her. However, Edison promises Ewald that he can improve upon his love, creating a mechanical substitute that will duplicate her body and improve upon her mind. As Edison boasts, “In a word, the present gorgeous little fool will no longer be a woman, but an angel; no longer a mistress but a lover; no longer reality, but the IDEAL.”¹⁵ Edison’s expounds at length the reasons why his android creation will be even better than the original, that he can capture every nuance about her form and movement, yet be “the murderer of her foolishness, the assassin of her triumphant animal nature.”¹⁶ In fact, when the time comes to compare the human with the machine, Edison is confident that the android will in fact seem more human than the real woman, who says to Ewald, “you will have to be careful, when you compare the two and listen to them both, *that it isn't the living woman who seems to you the doll.*”¹⁷ In fact, the name that Edison gives to his new creation is Hadaly, a word he says means “ideal” in Iranian. (The origin of “Hadaly” is not true, as Anne Greenfield points out, “but her three creators—Villiers, Edison and Ewald—all think so.”¹⁸)

Edison had originally begun his research into creating the Hadaly android because of his friend Anderson, who was seduced by a young woman

and ended up ruining his fortune. In the end, Anderson ended up killing himself. Edison wanted to create a substitute companion for men that would be more suitable and genial than modern women, who, Edison asserted, had a deleterious effect on men of substance through their surface charms. However, as Edison discovered, even the woman who “ruined” his friend Anderson was not particularly attractive once her make-up had been removed. In creating Hadaly, which Edison predicts will go into mass production in just a few years, the master inventor has created what he sees as the perfect pairing for intelligent men. In one of Edison’s monologues in which he is addressing his imaginary critics regarding the android, he states the words that Oshii took as the epigraph for *Innocence*: “I have come with this message: Since our gods and our aspirations are no longer anything but *scientific*, why shouldn’t our loves be so, too?”¹⁹

Once Edison makes the final modifications to Hadaly, she fools Lord Ewald by pretending to be Alicia, demonstrating that Edison was correct that his android could imitate, and improve upon, the original human model. However, throughout the story, Edison had been in contact with a mysterious being he was calling Sowana. In fact, Miss Anny Sowana ends up being Mrs. Anny Anderson—the wife whom Mr. Anderson had abandoned. Through advanced experiments in hypnotism to try to cure her depressed mental state, Edison had eventually become able to communicate with her telepathically. She helped and encouraged Edison with his plan for building Hadaly and eventually “she was able, *occasionally*, TO INCORPORATE HERSELF WITHIN IT, AND ANIMATE IT WITH HER ‘SUPERNATURAL’ BEING.”²⁰ So, Edison says, the construction of Hadaly “has not resulted in an empty or lifeless imitation. A soul has been added to it” and within her form “now lurks a feminine being who is, and perhaps always was, the true and rightful possessor of this extraordinary beauty, since she has shown herself worthy of it.”²¹ However, on his way back to Great Britain with Hadaly, Lord Ewald’s ship sinks, and although the man is able to escape, the android is lost at sea.

From this synopsis, the influence that *Tomorrow’s Eve* had on *Innocence* is clear. Although the novel puts forth its arguments in the most base and

chauvinistic manner, denigrating the very nature of women, it points to a long-held dream of artificial life and love. Similarly, *Innocence* posits that relations between people and machines are inexorably intertwined, and that love is possible. The two also seem to agree with the difficulties of making such artificial creatures truly live. The physical form is a relatively simple matter, accomplished through plausible advances in engineering. But the “soul” or the “ghost” is another matter entirely. Both *Tomorrow’s Eve* and *Innocence* conceptualize artificial beings that still need some active element of the human to be real. In the case of *Tomorrow’s Eve*, it is the spirit of Sowana, who is able to use her psychic powers to take control of Hadaly. For *Innocence*, it is the essences of the kidnapped children that are “ghost dubbed” into the Locus Solus gynoids. Of course, even though it is Oshii who explicitly references the novel in his film, this is an aspect that was present in Shirow’s original manga.

As we can see in *Tomorrow’s Eve*, the idea of a romantic relationship with a machine is not only a contemporary one. Such ideas have propagated at various points throughout the nineteenth, twentieth, and twenty-first centuries. Oshii has surmised that Hadaly was the inspiration for the android Maria in Fritz Lang’s *Metropolis* (1927), who “bewitched” him when he saw it as a student: “If the movie survives the specificity of its times and succeeds in retaining its universal value today, that’s down to the creation of that android alone. I dare say that if we tried to go back and search for the origin of both Hollywood actresses and Japanese animation heroines, we’d eventually get to the android Maria.”²² In this way, *Tomorrow’s Eve*, through *Metropolis*, has cast a long shadow on the history of filmmaking that has followed it—in *Innocence*, Oshii is just making such debts explicit. But thoughts about such fictional characters have influenced real-world robotics as well. Steven T. Brown notes that Hadaly was also the name of a Japanese robot developed at Waseda University in the mid-1990s to study human/machine interactions.²³

Another striking allusion Oshii uses in *Innocence* is his incorporation of the works of Hans Bellmer, a twentieth-century German artist most famous

for his erotically charged illustrations, photographs, and dolls. Therese Lichtenstein asserts that Bellmer's art is primarily political, that "the dolls that Bellmer constructed and photographed were in part a response to the rise of fascism in Germany. Bellmer's works are a violent attack on the stereotypes of normalcy evident in Nazi art and culture."²⁴ However, Sue Taylor is more skeptical of relatively straightforward interpretations like this, writing that Bellmer's own self-narrative and his artistic revolt line up well with the "conventional tropes of the avant-garde for the free-spirited artist pitted against the corrupt bourgeois. Perhaps this is one reason for the nearly universal, unquestioning acceptance in the literature of Bellmer's promotion of his art as a liberating struggle against the father, the police, and, ultimately, fascism and the state."²⁵ These varying interpretations demonstrate that Bellmer is a complex artist, the interpretation of whose work is not immediately evident. Is such art a revolt against prevailing social and artistic norms, or is it exploitative and pornographic? Are the two necessarily mutually exclusive? It is worth noting that, according to Taylor, Bellmer had a "habit of coaxing little girls from the orphanage near his parents' home in Karlsruhe to model for paintings and drawings" in his early development as an artist.²⁶ This use of young girls has an interesting parallel with *Innocence*, although this is an aspect that was present in Shirow's original work before Oshii added the Bellmer influences to the story. It, therefore, seems unlikely that Bellmer's real-life use of young girls played a role in the generation of the story. However, it may have had a role, conscious or not, in Oshii's use of such imagery.

Such connotations are necessarily brought into any works, like *Innocence*, that use ideas and concepts from Bellmer. The first reference to Bellmer's art we see is when Batou encounters the gynoid that claws at her artificial skin and opens up her chest, an image very similar to Bellmer's sketch *Rose ouverte la nuit* (*Rose Open at Night*, 1935–1936). From here, the scenes in the credit sequence of gynoid construction tie the female robots even more closely to the dolls that Bellmer constructed, and, later in the story, Batou even finds a copy of a book of Bellmer's art in Volkerson's house. Unfortunately, a full account of Bellmer's art is beyond the scope of

this single chapter, so I would like to refer interested readers to works by Livia Monnet²⁷ and Steven T. Brown,²⁸ both of whom do an excellent job of analyzing the meanings of such works in the context of Oshii's film.

In addition to such artistic and literary references, *Innocence* is filled with many quotations in the dialogue exchanged by the characters. Steven T. Brown identifies the quotes in the film as coming from the Buddha, Confucius, the Bible, Milton, Zeami, Gogol, Julien Offray de La Mettrie, and Richard Dawkins, as well as "Meiji-period satirist" Saitō Ryokuu.²⁹ In particular, Brown focuses on the quote from famed Noh playwright Zeami—"Life and death come and go like marionettes dancing on a table. Once their strings are cut, they easily crumble"—noting that it appears in the film at three different times and that it "underscores the function of citationality throughout the film, as well as the performative aspect of animation itself."³⁰ Such quotes and references are foundational to the way people today think and communicate and, as Oshii notes, "people aren't aware of it."³¹ Indeed, this highlights the fact that human cognition and communication is shaped by referencing other things. Perhaps most famously, this has been detailed by George Lakoff and Mark Johnson in their book *Metaphors We Live By*, in which they assert, "Our ordinary conceptual system, in terms of which we both think and act, is fundamentally metaphorical in nature."³² The use of quotations in *Innocence* is important because it highlights the ways in which people think—it brings our common use of metaphor in thought and speech to the forefront. As Lakoff and Johnson argue, the objectivist position that we have access to absolute truths about how the world works "is unable to give a satisfactory account of human understanding and of any issues requiring such an account."³³ The quotations and metaphors in the script of *Innocence* reinforce the work done by the animation in showcasing the slipperiness of reality and the importance of trying to get a grasp on ways of understanding.

One of the major advances Oshii brings to *Innocence* is a focus on points of view and subjective experiences, which is related to this use of textual metaphor. As we have explored in previous chapters, the blurring of

the lines between reality and fantasy (or false reality) is a common theme throughout Oshii's works. However, Oshii takes advantage of advances in computer graphics to depict new scenes and to set up shots that would not have been previously feasible in anime. The viewer is first presented with such a scene at the beginning of the film when Batou investigates the rogue gynoid at the end of an alleyway. As he advances on the criminal, the viewer is presented with a series of POV shots from Batou's perspective. We see what Batou sees, including the additional information that his cyberbrain processes and overlays atop the visual image. The smooth tracking of the Batou's viewpoint as he progresses through the alley would not have been possible even a few years earlier, and the additional information shown on-screen highlights the fact that what the viewer is experiencing is a new way of looking at the world in anime. However, such a first-person point of view had been common for a while in computer games—perhaps this is a further manifestation of the influence that the early 1980s dungeon role playing game *Wizardry* had on Oshii.

Subjective experience is highlighted at other points in the film as well. Probably the most noteworthy scene to depict this is the “shootout” that occurs in the convenience store when Batou goes to pick up some food for his dog. This single scene took the animators ten months to create, and is different in feel from the scenes that come before or after. According to animation director Toshihiko Nishikubo, this was intentional: “The idea is that the contrast in visual style here with the 3D is supposed to signify how this is a hacked realm.”³⁴ In other words, the use of a CG perspective is supposed to unsettle the viewer and set this particular scene apart. What occurs onscreen does not strictly make sense; when the bullets begin flying, it is not clear where they are coming from, and the whole scene is in chaos until Ishikawa arrives to subdue Batou, at which point the color palette returns to normal. It is only when the colors change that the viewer may realize retroactively that this scene presented an altered reality. The entire shootout is not an objective view of what is actually occurring in the store, but rather highlights the nature of Batou's perception of the outside world, even in those shots

that do not occur from Batou's point of view. This scene primes the viewer for subsequent questioning of the layers of reality that occur when Batou and Togusa visit Kim's mansion. This highlighting of the nature of perception and the questioning of our standard points of view is something Oshii likes to do in many of his projects, and which I address in more depth in the conclusion.

The film cemented Oshii's reputation as a director at the cutting edge of not only conceptualizing futuristic technologies, but using them as well. A humorous example of this can be read in *The Kurosagi Corpse Delivery Service* (*Kurosagi Shitai Takuhaibin*) by Eiji Ōtsuka and Hōsui Yamazaki, which follows a group of perpetually broke college students, some of whom can use supernatural abilities. In the third and fourth chapters of the ninth volume, we are introduced to the urban legend of a man who seems to just be a floating head. He is seen riding around at night on a motorcycle and is caught on tape peeping in the locker room of a women's spa. The man's name is Oshii and artist Yamazaki has even drawn him to look like the director. It turns out he was working at "Esuefu University Optical Institute" (a play on the Japanese pronunciation of "SF" for science fiction) and had developed a suit that allowed for near-complete invisibility—"Like in Shirow Masamune's *Ghost in the Shell*" a character says at one point.³⁵ The Oshii in the story didn't approve of the lab being funded by military research money, so he kept his invention to himself and used it for peeping at women, until he was murdered by his coworker at the lab who wanted the data on the suit for himself. However, the protagonists are able to solve the crime and the fictional Oshii manages to exact his ghostly revenge on his coworker.

Upon its release, *Innocence* became one of the most impressive examples of contemporary animation, Japanese or not. It played at the Cannes film festival in 2004, where it was tied with *Shrek 2* (2004, dir. Andrew Adamson, Kelly Asbury, and Conrad Vernon) for being the fifth animated film to have competed there—the previous films had been *Dumbo* (1941, dir. Ben Sharpsteen), *Peter Pan* (1953, dir. Clyde Geronimi, Wilfred Jackson, and Hamilton Luske), *Fantastic Planet* (1973, dir. René Laloux) and *Shrek* (2001,

dir. Andrew Adamson and Vicky Jenson). However, as noted film critic J. Hoberman wrote, "For all its graphic splendor, fluid action, surrealist attitudes, and self-aware cyber-philosophizing, *Innocence* was indifferently received when shown in competition at the 2004 Cannes Film Festival. Was it a cartoon trying to pass for something real?"³⁶ One might have thought that the complex themes and European arthouse influences might have charmed a Cannes crowd, but perhaps, like many, they were put off by the very notion of taking animation as seriously as they do live-action film. This put *Innocence* in a precarious position—it was too adult and philosophical for many anime otaku, but, as animation, it had a hard time being taken seriously by a film-centric crowd. Oshii himself admitted as much during the production of the film: "The content of this move is kind of strange. It's a drama for older audiences. One may question making an adult drama in anime, but I made it with a hope that it may eventually be useful for younger audiences someday."³⁷ This brings up the question of whether a film like *Innocence* should even be classified as anime. It seems to be outside the cycle of animalized consumption of database elements performed by fans of many contemporary anime as described by Hiroki Azuma in his book *Otaku: Japan's Database Animals*.³⁸ Veteran actor Naoto Takenaka, who voiced Kim in *Innocence*, agrees with the idea that the film is something different, asserting, "Oshii-san's [films] aren't really anime. They've gone beyond the border of anime. I almost wonder if there's a good category for it."³⁹

In many ways, *Innocence* is a landmark film, both in terms of Oshii's career and Japanese animation in general. After finishing *Innocence*, Oshii said, "With this film now, I believe I've said everything that can be said within the framework of this particular series."⁴⁰ Elsewhere, Oshii suggested that *Innocence* may be the end of his anime career: "I put all my effort into making this film. Now, I can't make any more anime beyond this; I think I can't do any more."⁴¹ Of course, as you may have been able to infer from the fact that this is not the final chapter of the book, Oshii has continued to direct films after *Innocence*. However, perhaps in an effort not to be pigeonholed (or maybe due to the many years it took to create *Innocence*) for his next works,

Oshii moved away from the cyberpunk sheen of *Ghost in the Shell* while still focusing on the intersections of history and technology.

Around this time the *Ghost in the Shell* franchise began slowing down as well. After the *2nd Gig* television show, Kenji Kamiyama directed *Ghost in the Shell: Solid State Society* in 2006. However, no new *Ghost in the Shell* animation would be released until 2013, when *Ghost in the Shell: Arise* debuted. Directed by Kazuchika Kise, this new series is being animated by Production I.G and is being distributed in a manner that is becoming increasingly common—a limited theatrical run, soon followed by a home video release. As of this writing, only the first film in the four-part series is available; it follows the adventures of Kusanagi, Batou, Togusa, and some of the rest of the team prior to the formation of Section 9. Based on the events that occur, it seems to be another narrative universe distinct from the three that have already been shown (the worlds of Shirow's manga, Oshii's films, and Kamiyama's TV shows and *Solid State Society*). Even after *Arise* concludes, it is possible that even more *Ghost in the Shell* animation will be created. Mitsuhiro Ishikawa has said that he would like *Ghost in the Shell* to be for Production I.G like *Mobile Suit Gundam* has been for Sunrise—a franchise that keeps getting readapted and reimagined throughout the years.⁴²

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